

Cautions In excessive doses, sweet woodruff can cause internal bleeding. Do not use if taking conventional medication for circulatory problems, or during pregnancy.

Aspidosperma quebracho-blanco (Apocynaceae)

Quebracho

Description Tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has thick corky bark, leathery leaves, and tubular white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Quebracho is found in the southern half of South America. The bark and timber are used commercially.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Quebracho contains indole alkaloids (including yohimbine) and tannins.

History & Folklore The name quebracho comes from the Spanish *quebrar* (to break) and *hacha* (axe), an allusion to the hardness of this tree's wood.

Medicinal Actions & Uses With its antispasmodic effect on the bronchial tubes, quebracho is used therapeutically to treat asthma and emphysema. It is also a tonic and reduces fever. This herb is astringent and has been used externally on wounds and burns.

Related Species Many other species of *Aspidosperma* are grown for tanning and timber in South America. Some are also considered fever remedies. One, *A. excelsum*, is used to relieve gas, stomach problems, and indigestion.

❗ **Cautions** Take only under professional supervision. Quebracho is toxic in excessive doses. It is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Atractylodes macrocephala (Asteraceae)

Bai Zhu

Description Erect perennial herb growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has alternate oval- to lance-shaped leaves and purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation *Bai zhu* is rare in the wild. It is cultivated in China, Japan, and Korea. The rhizome is unearthed in late autumn or winter.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents *Bai zhu* contains a volatile oil (0.35–1.35%), which includes atractylol, and the lactones atractylenolide II and III. Atractylol has a liver-protective activity.

History & Folklore The first record of the use of *bai zhu* is in the *Tang Materia Medica*, written in China in 659 CE. Later, it was one of the 4 herbs that made up the “decoction of the 4 rulers,” a

mixture prescribed by Wang Ji (1463–1539) as a treatment for syphilis.

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Bai zhu* has traditionally been used as a tonic, building *qi* (see p. 40) and strengthening the spleen. The rhizome has a sweet, pungent taste, and is used to relieve fluid retention, excessive sweating, and digestive problems such as diarrhea and vomiting. Combined with Baical skullcap (*Scutellaria baicalensis*, p. 134), it is employed to prevent miscarriage.

Avena sativa (Poaceae)

Oats

Description Annual grass growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has straight hollow stems, blade-like leaves, and small spikes holding seeds (grain).

Habitat & Cultivation Native to northern Europe, oats are now grown in temperate regions worldwide as a cereal crop. They are harvested in late summer.

Parts Used Seeds, straw (dried stems).

Constituents Oats contain saponins, alkaloids, sterols, flavonoids, silicic acid, starch, proteins (including gluten), vitamins (especially B vitamins), and minerals (especially calcium).

History & Folklore Formerly, oat straw was used to fill mattresses, proving beneficial to those suffering from rheumatism. In *The English Physician* (1652) Nicholas Culpeper states that “a poultice made of meal of oats and some oil of bay helpeth the itch and the leprosy.” Earlier, in 1597, John Gerard was less enthusiastic: “Oatmeal is good to make a fair and well-coloured maid to look like a cake of tallow.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Oats are best known as a nutritious cereal, but they benefit health in many other ways. Oat bran lowers cholesterol, and an oat-based diet may improve stamina (see *Research*). Oats, and oat straw in particular, are tonic when taken medicinally. Oat straw is prescribed by medical herbalists to treat general debility and a wide variety of nervous conditions. The grains and straw are mildly antidepressant, gently raising energy levels and supporting an overstressed nervous system. Oats are used to treat depression and nervous debility, and insomnia in those suffering from nervous exhaustion. Oats are one of the principal herbal aids to convalescence after a long illness. Externally, the grain is emollient and cleansing, and a decoction strained into a bath can help soothe itchiness and eczema.

Research In research undertaken in Australia, athletes who were placed on an oat-based diet for 3 weeks showed a 4% increase in stamina. Oats are thought to help maintain muscle function during training and exercise.

Self-help Uses Depression & decreased vitality, p. 316; Eczema, p. 300; Nervous exhaustion & stress, p. 319; Poor sleep & nervous exhaustion, p. 309.

Bacopa monnieri (Scrophulariaceae) Water Hyssop, Brahmi (Hindi)

Description Creeping succulent perennial growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has spatula-shaped fleshy leaves and pale blue or white flowers on long, slender stalks.

Habitat & Cultivation Water hyssop grows in warmer temperate and tropical climates, especially in southern Asia. It thrives in marshland, developing into dense mats on mudflats and at the edges of mangrove swamps.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

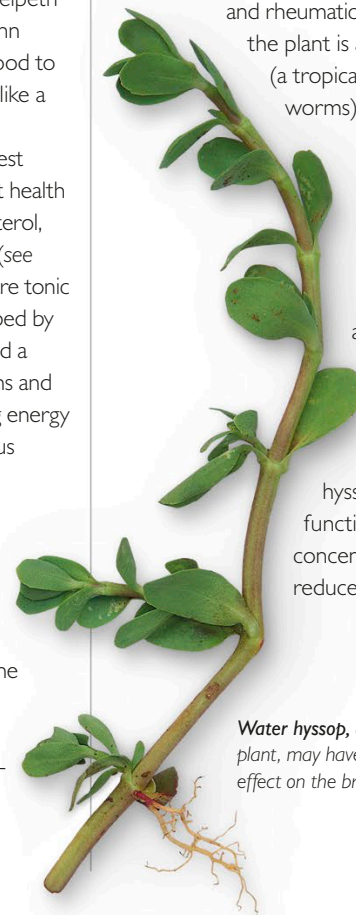
Constituents Water hyssop contains triterpenoid saponins, including bacosides.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In India, water hyssop is used principally for disorders of the nervous system, such as neuralgia, epilepsy, and mental illness, but it is also employed for a wide range of other disorders, including indigestion, ulcers, gas and constipation, asthma and bronchitis, and infertility. In China, it is taken as a *yang* tonic for impotence, premature ejaculation, infertility,

and rheumatic conditions. In Indonesia, the plant is a remedy for filariasis (a tropical disease caused by worms). In Cuba, water hyssop is used as a purgative, and a decoction of the whole plant is taken as a diuretic and laxative. The expressed juice is mixed with oil and applied as a rub for arthritic pain.

Research

Indian research suggests that water hyssop improves mental function, memory, and concentration, as well as reduces learning time.



Water hyssop, a swamp plant, may have a tonic effect on the brain.